

FEEL BEFORE YOU BUILD

Hands-on prototyping with actuators · 2 hours

TLDR

Two hours finding out what actuators feel like, and leaving able to drive one from your own code.

Get a board and run task 01. Something spins.

Change two numbers, upload again. That loop is the workshop.

Pick up the actuators you are not driving.

Work through as many of the five tasks as you get to.

Build one signal someone else can read without looking.

WHY WE ARE HERE

You can read a datasheet. You have never held one of these.

Most projects end up on the screen and the speaker

- Not because touch was wrong
- Because nobody knew the lab has 117 coin motors

Today: decide it feels cheap, pick something else

- Better now than in week 46

HOW TODAY WORKS

A board each, five tasks, everything pre-wired

- Upload, change two numbers, upload again
- You wire nothing today

Actuators are on the tables at the front

- Go and feel the ones your task does not use

Finish by building one signal someone else can read

RUN SHEET

Times are offsets from the start. The only hard checkpoint is 0:25: everyone has task 01 running.

0:00	10 min	Two motors, same message. Which felt urgent?
0:10	15 min	Boards out, task 01 running for everyone
0:25	60 min	Tasks 02 to 05, at your own pace
1:25	10 min	Round-the-room: what surprised you
1:35	20 min	Blind test on task 05
1:55	5 min	Pack down

FIVE TASKS, ONE BOARD EACH

Upload, change two numbers, upload again. That loop is the point.

- 01 Make something spin** **coin motor**
- 02 Make something tap** **solenoid**
- 03 Make something warm** **Peltier tile**
- 04 Make it notice you** **a wire and foil**
- 05 Make it answer back** **both together**
- 06 Use what you have** **sensors.chomskylab.dk**

1 to 3 output, 4 input, 5 both. Nobody finishes all six.

HOW THE TASK SKETCHES WORK

Every sketch runs the moment you upload it. Nothing to wire. All of them:
github.com/labtools-au/multimodal-actuator-workshop

A CHANGE ME block at the top

- Two or three numbers. Edit, upload, feel the difference

A THINGS TO TRY list at the bottom

- Four experiments, roughly in order of difficulty
- The last one is usually the interesting one

WHAT YOU GET IN THE BASE KIT

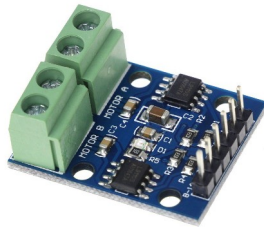
One set per pair, collected before you start task 01. Below: the three parts people always come back for.

Board, breadboard, jumper wires, resistors: on the tables.

Not in the drawers, so take what you need.



Breadboard supply, 8A. Anything past an LED.

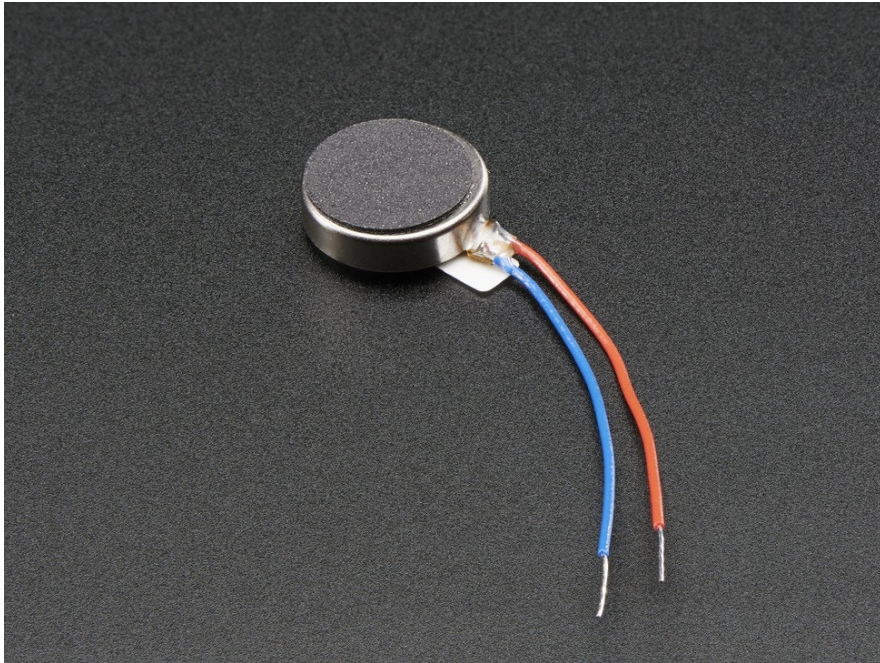


L9110S H-bridge, 2C. Reversing, and the Peltier.



PAM8403 amp, 11F. A transducer needs one.

VIBRATING MINI MOTOR DISC



An off-centre weight on a motor shaft, sealed in a disc. The same part as in your phone.

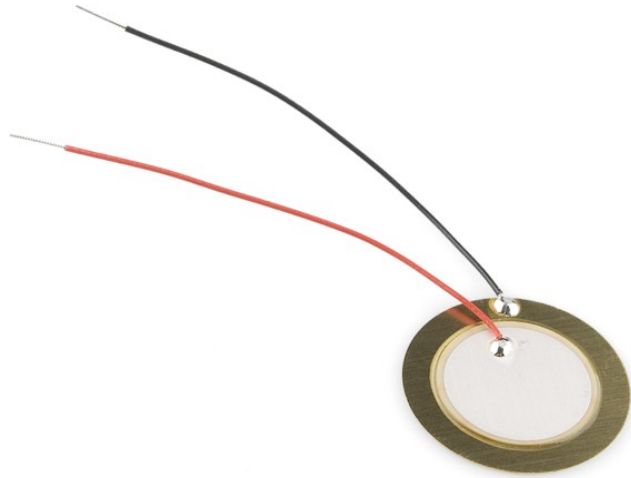
Feels like: a buzz you cannot make gentle and fast at once.

USED FOR

Phone notifications, controller rumble, anything worn under clothing.

1E | 117 | 2.5-3.8V rated | 100 mA at 5V | PWM

PIEZO ELEMENT



A crystal that flexes when you put current across it. Near-instant, almost no power, but shallow.

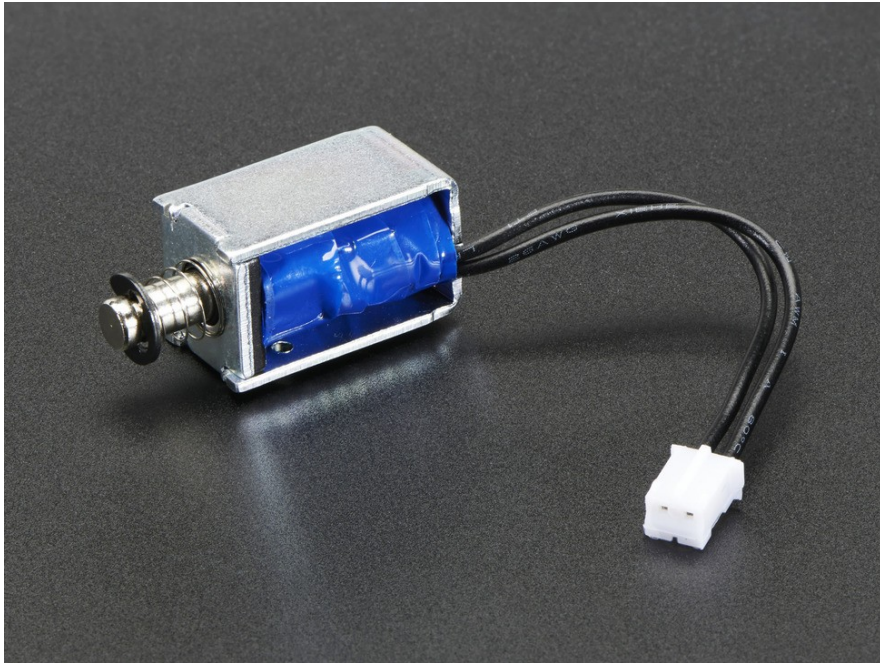
Feels like: a tick, not a thump.

USED FOR

Clicks and confirmations. Anything where lag would feel broken.

Drawer 6F | 69 in stock | any digital pin

MINI PUSH-PULL SOLENOID



A coil that yanks a metal rod when you energise it. No half a tap: it fires or it does not.

Feels like: a person tapping you, not a machine signalling.

USED FOR

Navigation cues on the body, braille cells, alerts in noise.

3E | 24 | 5V, 1.1 A, 4.5 ohm | 3mm throw, 80g

CAPACITIVE PAD



A wire taped behind foil, card or fabric. No sensor and no breakout board, which is why the box on the left is empty.

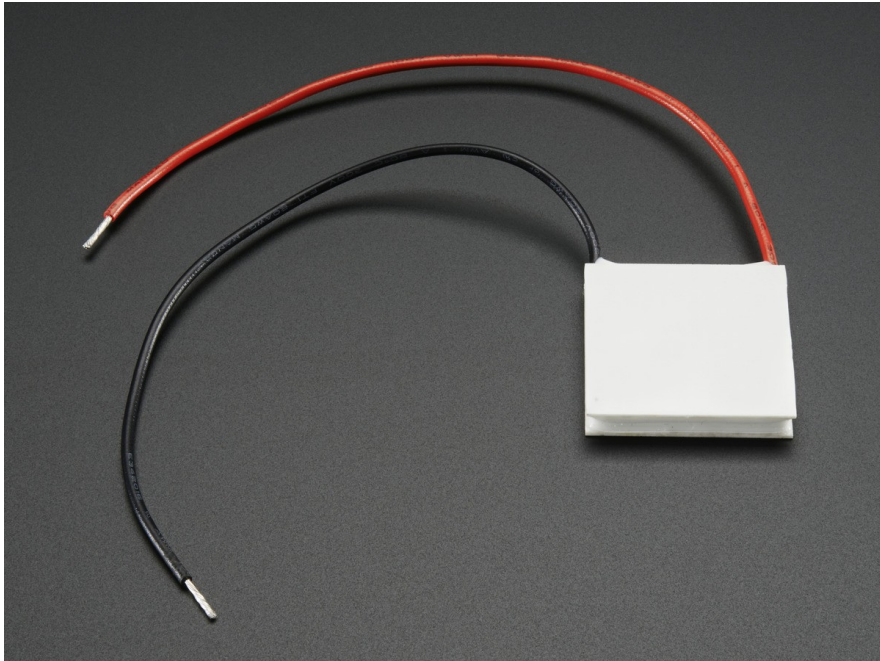
Feels like: nothing. That is the point. The surface stays plain.

USED FOR

Invisible controls in wood or fabric, waterproof panels.

No drawer, no part number, no cost. Any analogue pin

PELTIER TILE



Heats one face and cools the other. Flip the current and it reverses.

Feels like: slow. Several seconds before you are sure which way.

USED FOR

Slow ambient state. Never an alert.

Drawer 4C | 25 small, 35 big | needs an H bridge

SURFACE TRANSDUCER



Turns any surface into a speaker. Drive it so one frequency is felt and another is heard, from the same part.

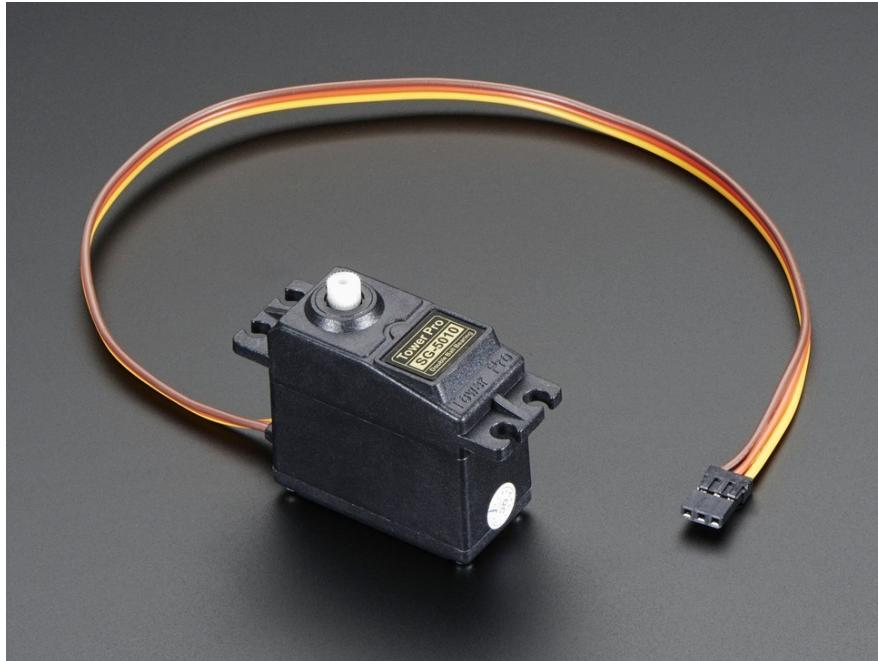
Feels like: more certain, rather than louder.

USED FOR

Noisy or bright environments, and accessibility.

Drawer 7F | 12 large, 13 medium, 23 bone | needs an amp

SERVO



A motor that holds a position instead of spinning freely. Tell it an angle and it goes there.

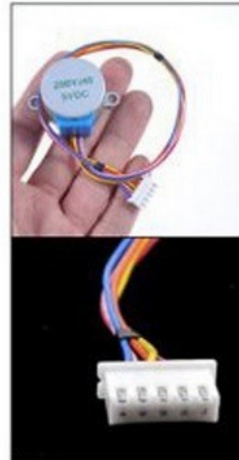
Feels like: something deliberate moving, with force behind it.

USED FOR

Anything that points, pushes, opens or resists a hand.

Drawer 2F | 80 in stock | Servo.h | needs its own 5V

STEPPER MOTOR



Moves in fixed steps rather than continuously, so you always know where it is without a sensor.

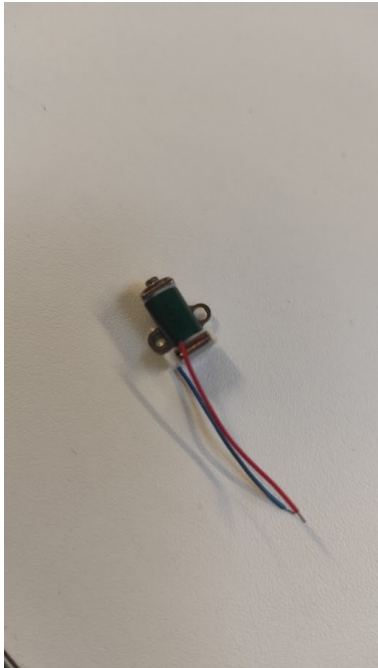
Feels like: precise, and audibly clicky.

USED FOR

Slow accurate motion. Dials, sliders, anything positioned.

2A | 44 | ULN2003 driver | 2048 steps/rev

ELECTROMAGNET



Grabs and releases ferrous metal on command. No moving parts of its own.

Feels like: a grip that appears and vanishes.

USED FOR

Latches, holds, and anything that should let go on cue.

Drawer 3D | 17 mini, 11 standard | needs a MOSFET

FREESTYLE, WITHIN THREE LIMITS

You do not have to do the tasks in order, or finish them. Playing properly with two beats rushing all five.

If you want to drive something not in front of you, go get it.

The three things that are not negotiable

- Solenoid and Peltier get their own supply, never USB
- The Peltier heatsink goes on before it is switched on
- No motor straight from a pin. 40 mA limit, it wants 75

THE ONE THAT SURPRISES PEOPLE

Touch input for the price of a wire. The thinking is where it costs you.

reading > baselineAverage() * 1.01

Threshold is relative, never absolute

- Readings drift with humidity and mains hum
- Fixed threshold works at 9am, fails at 1pm

Baseline only learns while untouched

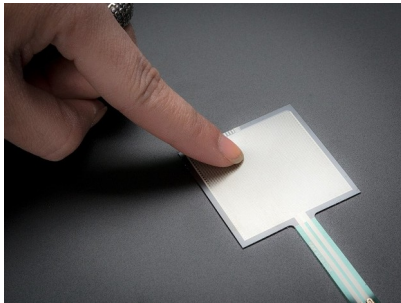
- Or a long press teaches it that a finger is normal

INPUTS, AND PRIOR ART

INPUTS WORTH KNOWING ABOUT

One table with a sign. Wander over between tasks.

- Capacitive touch. A wire. That is task 04
- GSR, drawer 0C5. Exactly one in the lab, so ask first



Force (FSR), 4A. 46 tiny, 33 square. Calibrate each one.



Flex, 4B. Only 8 left, so share them.



Pulse, 9D. 9 in stock. Steady at rest, useless once moving.

YOU ALREADY WRITE CODE. WHY COME?

Fair question. Three honest answers.

You cannot Google what something feels like

- No datasheet says a knock reads as a person, a buzz as a machine

The parts are free and already here

- Borrowing beats ordering. Nothing to buy, nothing to wait for

Your devices hide sensors you may not be able to reach

- Find out today which open up, and which are locked

REVERSE ENGINEER WHAT YOU ALREADY OWN

The trackers in your pocket and on your wrist. What opens up, and what does not.

BLE heart rate strap: readable from a web page

- Web Bluetooth, standard GATT. Chrome and Edge only

Most Garmin watches: the same, with no app

- Turn on Broadcast Heart Rate and it acts as a strap

Apple Watch: nothing live, whatever you write

- HealthKit needs a watchOS app in Swift

Garmin history: Connect IQ, or the API afterwards

- Good for analysis. Useless for reacting in real time

WHAT A PHONE WILL AND WILL NOT GIVE YOU

Open sensors.chomskylab.dk on your own phone right now.

Works in a web page

- Accelerometer and gyroscope, microphone, camera
- Pointer pressure, though a trackpad reports only 0 or 0.5

Does not, whatever the tutorial says

- Phone vibration on iOS. WebKit has never shipped it, at any version, and Chrome on iOS is Safari underneath

So "the phone buzzes" works on no iPhone in this room.

- Check the feature, not the tutorial, before it is in a plan.

TWO RIGS THAT ALREADY EXIST

Built here, by students at roughly your stage.

Moving screen, Arduino Uno

- Breathes when idle. Retreats when touched
- Easing and idle motion do the work. A dozen lines

Instrumented sock, ESP32

- Six force sensors under a foot, batched over Wi-Fi
- Calibrate per sensor. Batch your writes

BUILD ONE SIGNAL

THE BRIEF

30 minutes. Not long enough to be precious about it.

One actuator. Three messages

- Arrived. Something wrong. Finished

Vary two things only

- Rhythm of the pulses, and how strong they are

Blind test: they name all three

- Note which two got confused, and why

THE CONSTRAINT THAT MATTERS

The recipient cannot look at the device.

If it only works while someone watches a screen,
you built a visual interface with a motor glued to it.

BEFORE YOU CALL IT DONE

Hand your device to another group with the screen turned away.

- They can tell all three messages apart
- It does not fire continuously when held
- You know which two got confused, and why

What you actually leave with

- What things feel like, how to drive one, and which to pick
- That last one is the expensive mistake this prevents

GO AND TOUCH THINGS

github.com/labtools-au/multimodal-actuator-workshop